Lesson 16: Vocabulary Strategies: Unfamiliar Words and Context Clues

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.10: Dealing with Unfamiliar Vocabulary; and from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 6.5: Using Context Clues.

In this lesson

You will learn what to do when you meet unfamiliar words: keep reading when you can, and when a word matters, use context clues, word parts (prefixes and suffixes), and a dictionary or thesaurus. Psychology lectures and textbooks are full of new words and technical terms, so these strategies let you read faster and still understand.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Decide when to keep reading and when to work out the meaning of a new word.
- Identify three types of context clue and the signal words for each.
- Use common prefixes and suffixes to guess a word's meaning and part of speech.
- Use a dictionary and a thesaurus carefully.
- Write definitions and examples into your own text, so that readers understand technical terms.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
context clue	information in the words around an unknown word that helps you guess its meaning	Context clues are all of the words around a word.
brief definition / restatement	the text gives the meaning directly, or says it again in other words	Deportation, or the removal from a country, can occur when immigrants lack legal papers.
synonym / antonym	a word with the same meaning / the opposite meaning	I abhor clothes shopping, but I adore grocery shopping.
example clue	examples that show what a word means	Signal words: such as, for instance, for example
signal word	a word or punctuation mark that shows a clue is coming	or, is, as, means, known as, refers to; dashes; commas

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
prefix	a word part added at the beginning to create a new meaning	dis + satisfied = dissatisfied
suffix	a word part added at the end; it often shows the part of speech	demonstrate + -tion = demonstration
part of speech	the grammatical class of a word: noun, verb, adjective, adverb	-ify makes verbs: simplify, classify
thesaurus	a reference book of words with the same or similar meanings	Look at the example sentences in a thesaurus.
jargon	the technical language of a special field	To "eighty-six" an item means to remove it from the menu.
surmise	guess from the evidence you have	A reader could confidently surmise that the word means a fear of cats.

Rules and explanations

First: keep reading

- Do not look up every new word. It slows your reading a lot and often does not help you understand or remember. Underline new words and keep reading; at the end, decide which ones to look up and study.
- Use a strategy when a word appears several times, or when it stops you from understanding the whole text. The three strategies are: context clues; word structure (roots, prefixes, suffixes); a dictionary and other reference tools.

Context clues

Type of clue	Signals	Example from the books
Brief definition or restatement	the word or; commas; dashes; is, as, means, known as, refers to	If you visit Alaska, you will likely see many glaciers, or slow moving masses of ice. / Marina was indignant — fuming mad — when she discovered her brother had left for the party without her.
Synonym	and	When you interpret an image, you actively question and examine what the image connotes and suggests.
Antonym (contrast)	but	I abhor clothes shopping, but I adore grocery shopping.
Example	such as, for instance, for example	I knew Mark's ailurophobia was in full force because he began trembling and stuttering when he saw my cat, Ludwig, slink out from under the bed. (ailurophobia = a fear of cats)

- A restatement is not always a formal definition: "fuming mad" is not a dictionary definition of indignant, but it shows the meaning.

- Jargon is the technical language of a field, at work or in a subject. If you cannot understand it from the context, ask.

Word structure: prefixes and suffixes

Common prefixes (Table 1.9.1): dis- (not, opposite of: dissatisfied), mis- (wrongly: misspell), un- (not: unacceptable), re- (again: reelection), inter- (between: interrelated), pre- (before: prepay), non- (not: nonsense), super- (above: superscript), sub- (under: submerge), anti- (against: antibacterial).

Suffixes also show the part of speech:

Part of speech	Suffixes (examples)
Verb	-en (shorten), -ify (simplify, justify), -ise/-ize (symbolize, visualize)
Noun	-al (denial), -ant/-ent (assistant, consultant), -cy (fluency), -ence/-ance (preference), -er (teacher), -ity (similarity), -ment (development), -ness (preparedness), -ship (citizenship), -tion/-sion (education)
Adjective	-able (avoidable), -al (national), -ent (different), -ful (peaceful), -ive (effective), -less (careless), -ous (dangerous)
Adverb	-ly/-ily (carefully), -ward/-wards (backwards), -wise (clockwise)

- Some suffixes appear in two lists: -al makes nouns (refusal) and adjectives (professional); -ent makes nouns for a person who does something and adjectives (excellent). Look at the word's place in the sentence.

Reference tools

- Dictionary: use it when a word seems critical to the passage and you cannot work it out from the context or the word structure.
- Thesaurus: it gives words with the same or similar meanings, but these words cannot simply replace each other. Check the example sentences to see how each word is used.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic builds families of words mainly by fitting a root of (usually three) consonants into different patterns. English mostly adds prefixes and suffixes to a base word, and the suffix often shows the part of speech: document, undocumented; elect, election, reelection.

Practice

Exercise 1. Context clues in sentences about immigration. These sentences are from section 1.10. For each word, name the type of clue and write the meaning.

1. **Deportation,** or the removal from a country, can occur when immigrants lack legal papers.
2. The majority of **apprehensions** or arrests of undocumented immigrants take place on the border.

3. While more immigrants **reside** in the United States with legal papers (73% of immigrants), about 10.5 million live in the U.S. as undocumented immigrants.
4. Most U.S. citizens see a need for immigration **reform**, but a small percentage of people want current immigration policies to remain the same.
5. Families who choose to travel to the United States face many **barriers**, including a difficult trip across the border, few resources, and the possibility of deportation.
6. DACA was made possible by **activists** such as Jose Antonio Vargas and organizations who advocated for social and political change.

Exercise 2. Identify the context clue (College ESL Writers, Exercise 1). The book underlines the target words, but the underlining is not visible in the printed material. The target words are: 1 adroit, 2 entomologist, 3 irrelevant, 4 sage, 5 rancor, 6 mortified, 7 petulant, 8 conundrums, 9 omnivores, 10 effervescent. For each sentence in the lesson material, write the context clue. Then name the type of clue and guess the meaning.

Exercise 3. Name the context clue (College ESL Writers, Exercise 2). Read the paragraph about Maggie in the lesson material. Write the name of the context clue that helps to define each target word: precocious, flabbergasted, dexterity, gloated, agape. Then guess each meaning.

Exercise 4. Clues and word parts in a passage. Read the passage from "4 Reasons Why Migrant Children Arriving Alone to the US Create a 'Border Crisis'" by Ediberto Román (The Conversation) in section 1.10.

1. Do any words have a brief definition or restatement, a synonym or antonym, or an example that shows the meaning?
2. Which prefixes and suffixes can you recognize? What do they mean?

Speak with your tutor

- "Give me ten sentences, each with a difficult word and a context clue. I will guess the meaning and name the type of clue. Then tell me the real meaning."
- "Here is my vocabulary log from a PSYC 110 lecture: [paste]. Are my guesses correct? Which words are worth learning, and which can I skip?"
- "Give me a base word from psychology. I will add prefixes and suffixes to build a word family and say the part of speech of each word."
- "Check my answers to Exercises 2 and 3, and correct my pronunciation of the target words."

Read aloud

1. Aisha is very adroit on the balance beam, but Alejandra is rather clumsy.
2. I saw the entomologist, a scientist who studies insects, cradle the giant dung beetle in her palm.
3. Azmir was mortified, way beyond embarrassment, when his friends teamed up to shove him into the pool.
4. At first, her parents were flabbergasted—utterly blown away—by their daughter's ability.

5. Deportation, or the removal from a country, can occur when immigrants lack legal papers.
6. Word stress: a·DROIT, en·to·MOL·o·gist, MOR·ti·fied, PET·u·lant, co·NUN·drum, ef·fer·VES·cent, pre·CO·cious, FLAB·ber·gast·ed, dex·TER·i·ty, a·GAPE.

Writing task

A vocabulary log and a definition paragraph. Part A. Read one section of a psychology text: a PSYC 110 lecture transcript (for example Lecture 17, Chapter 6, "The Minor Mystery of Sleep") or a section of the free OpenStax textbook *Psychology 2e* (https://openstax.org/details/books/psychology-2e). Underline new words, but keep reading. Afterwards, choose five words. For each word, write: the sentence; the type of clue (if any); your guess; the word parts; the dictionary meaning.

Part B. Write a paragraph of 120-160 words that explains one idea from the text to a reader who has not studied psychology. Use three technical terms, and give each one a context clue: a definition or restatement (with or, commas or dashes), a synonym or antonym, and an example (with such as or for example).

Checklist:

- Every technical term has a clue that a reader can use.
- You used at least three different signals (or, dashes, such as, but ...).
- Each clue is accurate: you checked it in a dictionary or the textbook.
- Each word is the right part of speech (check the suffix: -tion noun, -ize verb, -ous adjective, -ly adverb).
- Commas or dashes come in pairs around a restatement in the middle of a sentence.
- If you used a thesaurus, you checked the example sentences.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Brief definition (signal: or, with commas): removal from a country.
2. Restatement (signal: or): arrests.
3. Synonym: live. Reside means live in a place (a formal word).
4. Antonym (signal: but): reform is the opposite of letting policies "remain the same"; it means changing a law or system to improve it.
5. Example: a difficult trip, few resources and the possibility of deportation are all things that block or slow a journey. A barrier is an obstacle.
6. Example (signal: such as): Jose Antonio Vargas and organizations that worked for change. An activist is a person who works actively for social or political change.

Exercise 2

1. adroit: "but Alejandra is rather clumsy". Antonym (signal: but). Meaning: skilful.
2. entomologist: "a scientist who studies insects". Brief definition (commas).
3. irrelevant: "and meaningless" (also: comments about politics in a lecture on plants). Synonym (signal: and). Meaning: not connected with the subject.
4. sage: "made a copy of my passport". Example: the advice was useful and sensible. Meaning: wise.
5. rancor: "or hatred". Brief definition or restatement (signal: or); "synonym" is also correct. Meaning: hatred, bitter dislike.
6. mortified: "way beyond embarrassment". Restatement (commas). Meaning: extremely embarrassed.
7. petulant: "on the contrary, not grouchy at all". Antonym (contrast signal: on the contrary). Meaning: bad-tempered, easily annoyed.
8. conundrums: "or riddles". Brief definition or restatement (signal: or); "synonym" is also correct. Meaning: riddles, puzzling problems.
9. omnivores: "people that eat both plants and animals". Brief definition (commas).
10. effervescent: "as excited as a cheerleader, for example". Example (signal: for example). Meaning: lively and enthusiastic.

Exercise 3

- precocious: example ("She produced brilliant watercolor paintings by the age of three"). Meaning: showing skills much earlier than usual.
- flabbergasted: restatement with dashes ("utterly blown away"). Meaning: extremely surprised.
- dexterity: brief definition (signal: or: "ease with which she used her hands"). Meaning: skill in using the hands.
- gloated: synonym (signal: or: "took pride in her paintings"). "Restatement" is also correct. Meaning: showed too much pride and pleasure in her own success.

- agape: antonym (signal: but: "her parents always kept their mouths closed"). Meaning: wide open.

Exercise 4

1. "Constituents": the next sentence restates the idea ("They have no voice within the U.S. democratic system"), and the last sentence adds that the children are "not part of any politician's voting bloc or reelection strategy". Constituents are the people a politician represents and who can vote for him or her. "Unaccompanied minors" restates "children" ("particularly children", "these children"): minors are children, and unaccompanied means without a parent or other adult. A "voting bloc" is a group of voters who vote together.
2. Prefixes: un- = not (undocumented, unaccompanied); re- = again (reelection). Suffixes: -ly makes adverbs (particularly, simply); -tion makes nouns (immigration, reelection); -ant/-ent = a person who performs an action (immigrants, constituents). Not in the tables: -ist and -ian also mean a person (journalists, politician), and -ic makes adjectives (democratic). Careful: re- in "represent" and "report" does not mean "again".

My notes